



THE PASO DEL Norte Bridge in Mexico stays open to motorists as migrant crossings hit historic lows. Photographs by ALEJANDRO CEGARRA For The Times

A BORDER TRANSFORMED BY CRACKDOWN, TARIFFS

Juan Ortíz trudged through 100-degree heat along the U.S.-Mexico border, weighed down by a backpack full of water bottles that he planned to leave for migrants trying to cross this rugged terrain.

Only there hadn't been many migrants of late.

When Ortíz started water drops in this especially dangerous stretch of desert near El Paso nearly two years ago, he sometimes encountered dozens of people trying to reach the U.S. in a single afternoon. Now he rarely sees any. Border crossings began falling during the final months of President Biden's term, and have plunged to their lowest levels in decades under President Trump.

"It's dramatically different," Ortíz said, the desert silent except for the crunch of his footsteps in the sand and the whir of a Border Patrol helicopter overhead. "Migrants no longer have any hope."

El Paso-Juárez communities upended by self-deportations, layoffs and military zones

By Kate Linthicum | REPORTING FROM EL PASO



RICHARD OSORIO, 35, in Ciudad Juárez, Mexico, said he left the U.S. after his husband was detained.

These borderlands surrounding El Paso were long a place of risk but also opportunity. Migrants chasing the American dream crossed by the tens of thousands annually, sometimes dodging federal agents and often seeking them out to ask for asylum.

But Trump's immigration crackdown — a total ban on asylum, a mass deportation campaign and the unprecedented militarization of the border — has altered life here in myriad ways.

Across the Rio Grande from El Paso in the Mexican city of Ciudad Juárez, shelters once hummed with life, rich with the smell of cooked stews and the chatter of people plotting their passage to the U.S.

Today those shelters are largely empty, populated by migrants stranded in Mexico when Trump took office, and others who were in the United States but decided

Afghans in U.S. reel amid Trump policies

A travel ban and the loss of deportation protections raise alarm in California.

By MELISSA GOMEZ AND SUHAUNA HUSSAIN

Afghans who relocated to California have been reeling over the last few months and weeks as the Trump administration has moved to end deportation protections amid increasing efforts to further restrict Afghan na-

tionals from coming to the U.S.

Last week, despite efforts by an organization suing to maintain the protections, the Trump administration ended Temporary Protected Status for Afghans, which the U.S. granted in May 2022 after it withdrew military forces from Afghanistan. The status allowed Afghans to come to the U.S. and obtain work authorization, but it did not provide a pathway to citizenship.

"People are desperate," said Shawn VanDiver, the founder and president of

AfghanEvac, a nonprofit that supports the safe relocation of Afghan allies. "They've followed all the rules. They've done everything the U.S. asked them to do, and at every corner, the Trump administration has been blocking them."

The Trump administration in January suspended Afghan refugee programs and canceled scheduled flights for Afghans cleared by the government. In May, the State Department sent layoff notices to staff at the Coordinator for Afghan Relocation Efforts, known as

CARE, the agency tasked with working to ensure Afghans got settled in the U.S. with government support. And in June, Trump instituted a travel ban, suspending travel for Afghan nationals to the U.S. and leaving families who had been hoping to reunify stuck in limbo.

Afghans have increasingly gotten caught up in the Trump administration's efforts to ramp up deportations. In San Diego, an Afghan national who worked as a translator for

SEOUL — For many Americans, the apartment where 29-year-old IT specialist Lee Chang-hee lives might be the stuff of nightmares.

Located just outside the capital of Seoul, the building isn't very tall — just 16 stories — by South Korean standards, but the complex consists of 36 separate structures, which are nearly identical except for the building number displayed on their sides.

The 2,000-plus units come in the same standardized dimensions found everywhere in the country (Lee lives in an "84C," which has 84 square meters, or about 900 square feet, of floor space) and offer, in some ways, a ready-made life. The amenities scattered throughout the campus include a rock garden with a fake waterfall, a playground, a gym, an administration office, a senior center and a "moms cafe."

But this, for the most part, is South Korea's mid-

In South Korea, the *apateu* is housing king

Forget the white picket fence. High-rise living is the dream.

By Max Kim



APARTMENTS, the middle-class ideal of homeownership in South Korea, dot the Seoul landscape. TINA HSU Bloomberg

dle-class dream of homeownership — its version of a house with the white picket fence.

"The bigger the apartment complex, the better the surrounding infrastructure, like public transportation, schools, hospitals, grocery stores, parks and so on," Lee said. "I like how easy it is to communicate with the neighbors in the complex because there's a well-run online community."

Most in the country would agree: Today, 64% of South Korean households live in such multifamily housing, the majority of them in apartments with five or more stories.

Such a reality seems unimaginable in cities like Los Angeles, which has limited or prohibited the construction of dense housing in single-family zones.

"Los Angeles is often seen as an endless tableau of individual houses, each with their own yard and garden," Max Podemski, an L.A.-

L.A. raids go beyond 'worst of the worst'

Trump boasts of deporting criminals, but the numbers tell a far different story.

By JENNY JARVIE AND GABRIELLE LAMARR LEMEE

They called them the "worst of the worst." For more than a month and a half, the Trump administration has posted a barrage of mugshots of L.A. undocumented immigrants with long rap sheets.

Officials have spotlighted Cuong Chanh Phan, a 49-year-old Vietnamese man convicted in 1997 of second-degree murder for his role in slaying two teens at a high school graduation party.

They have shared blurry photos on Instagram of criminals such as Rolando Veneracion-Enriquez, a 55-year-old Filipino man convicted in 1996 of sexual penetration with a foreign object with force and assault with intent to commit a felony. And Eswin Uriel Castro, a Mexican convicted in 2002 of child molestation and in 2021 of assault with a deadly weapon.

But the immigrants whom the Department of Homeland Security showcase in X posts and news releases do not represent the majority of immigrants swept up across Los Angeles.

As the number of immigration arrests in the L.A. region quadrupled from 540 in April to 2,185 in June, 7 out of 10 immigrants arrested in

Fire escape plans remain untested

Law requires cities to evaluate viability of evacuation routes. L.A. hasn't done it.

By NOAH HAGGERTY

Just before sunrise on Nov. 8, 2018, a power line fell from a wind-worn Pacific Gas & Electric transmission tower and whipped into the structure nestled in the Sierra foothills. An electric arc sent molten metal into the dry vegetation below. It ignited.

Five minutes later, a PG&E employee spotted the fire while driving on a nearby highway and reported it.

Within two hours of the sighting, the town of Paradise, seven miles away, sent its first evacuation order, but it was already too late. Within two minutes, flames were reported at the town's edge. Landing embers quickly ignited dozens of spot fires in town. With only four major roads out of town, the streets quickly gridlocked. Paradise burned.

Sixty-four people died in Paradise during the agonizing seven-hour evacuation. Six of them were found in or next to their cars as they tried to evacuate.

Marc Levine, a state legislator at the time, listened over radio to the horrific scenes of people, stuck in



Special dishes for sunny days

A special section on summer cooking is included in today's newspaper for print subscribers and is available for purchase at shoplatimes.com/summercooking.

Grenade missing after deadly blast

Whereabouts of one of the two explosives found in a Santa Monica townhome complex are unknown. CALIFORNIA, B1

U.S. mosques vandalized

Muslim leaders are increasing security after reports of graffiti at sites in Los Angeles and Texas. NATION, A7



JAY L. CLENDENIN L.A. Times JUSTINE Bateman is among the critics of AI.

Hollywood tech is dividing opinions

De-aged stars, cloned voices, synthetic scenes: AI reprograms the art — and business — of acting. ENTERTAINMENT, E6

Weather

Partly sunny.

L.A. Basin: 80/61. B8

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